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Dems' supermajority hopes slipping away

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Democrats' chance at reclaiming their coveted supermajority appeared to be slipping away after voters in Southern California were favoring a Republican-led effort to recall a state senator over his support for a gas tax hike.

The recall of Sen. Josh Newman, D-Fullerton (Orange County), was ahead 63 percent to 38 percent in early returns.

The contest was one of four closely watched election results that will determine whether Democrats in the state Legislature will regain their two-thirds supermajority.

"This is an unmistakable rebuke of Sacramento's tax and spend ways," said recall leader Carl DeMaio.

Senate Democrats needed to hold Newman's seat for a chance at regaining their supermajority, which enables them to raise taxes and put constitutional amendments on the ballot without GOP help.

Newman faced a recall over his vote to increase gas taxes and vehicle registration fees last year.

Leading the race of possible replacements if Newman is recalled is former Assemblywoman Republican Ling Ling Chang, with 36 percent of the vote in early returns.

Other key races Tuesday:

Senate contest: A Los Angeles-area lawmaker running for the state Senate seat he was forced out of because of a sexual harassment scandal was trailing three challengers in early returns Tuesday night.

Former Sen. Tony Mendoza, D-Artesia (Los Angeles County), had 12 percent among a field of 11 candidates. The top challengers were Republican business owner Rita Topalian at 28 percent and Democratic Montebello Mayor Vanessa Delgado at 15 percent.

If no candidate receives a majority, the top two will face off Aug. 7.

Mendoza resigned in February after a Senate investigation found he "more likely than not" engaged in unwanted sexual advances toward six women. He then ran for the office in both the special election to fill the seat and the primary to determine who will move on to the November ballot for the next four-year term.

In the top-two primary election, Topalian (26 percent) and Democrat Pico Rivera City Councilman Bob Archuleta (17 percent) were leading. Mendoza had 10 percent.

Assembly contests: Democrats needed to win one of two special elections to regain their supermajority in the Assembly, which they lost last year when two Southern California members resigned amid sexual misconduct allegations: Assemblymen Matt Dababneh and Raul Bocanegra.

Primary elections for those seats were held in April, setting the stage for Tuesday's runoffs.

Democrat Luz Rivas held a 64 percent to 36 percent lead over Republican Ricardo Benitez for the seat once held by Bocanegra, with 11 percent of the vote counted. Democrat Jesse Gabriel led by 60 percent to 40 percent against Republican Justin Clark for Dababneh's vacancy, with 1 percent of the vote counted.

Bay Area: In the race to succeed Assemblyman Tony Thurmond, D-Richmond, who ran for state schools chief, Buffy Wicks jumped out front with 33 percent of the vote. Dan Kalb was in second-place with 16 percent in the top-two primary, with 8 percent of precincts counted.

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